

Week 11: Contextual design by Julie and Sears

I felt that this week's reading about CD (contextual design) was an extremely thorough and practically-oriented review of the process. Instead of a more theoretical overview of CD, it is geared much more towards industrial practitioners, similar to the persona reading from Week 9. My thoughts on this week's reading are much more scattered, pinpointing different aspects of the authors' explanation style rather than addressing some overall themes. This is partly also because the structure of this chapter is very discrete and sequential, and I don't have many strong opinions on the actual steps of CD as they are what they are and based on the cases presented seem to serve their intended purpose within the context of companies.

The most meaningful passage to me in this chapter was the one on page 951 talking about how "we're all different, but we're all alike." I think that emphasizing this concept is key to the 'contextualization' in CD, with respect to contextualization of users. Figuring out what individual differences are as well as patterned variations are across individuals, as well as possible connections between these factors, is key to gaining insight on how people in general do work or other activities. Thinking in the reference frame of notable differences and common similarities is also a widely generalizable, but easy way to come up with a lot of examples of human factors during brainstorming.

The example that I liked the most was the one about computers having sound on page 956. Again, it highlights *highly contextual* parts of CD that are not mentioned in the key steps or procedures we are told to do (model consolidation, storyboarding, etc.). The chapter explains how when gathering data in relation to a new or currently non-existing technology, we cannot gather data about its actual use (since that doesn't exist yet) but we can collect data on use in the context of the new technology – for example, exploring use and experience in the context of sound. Data on silence, noise, and meaningful sound, as well as general computer use, can be utilized to look at possible connections between these two things (sound and computer).

I found that some ways the authors explained certain steps of CD were particularly good. They didn't say this out loud in the chapter, but explaining Reverse User Environment Designs (p. 958) actually helped me gain an even better understanding of User Environment Designs, as it is an application of User Environment Design but in a very different context. Talking about the same concept in very different contexts, especially if it is kind of an abstract one, is very helpful for understanding. It was hard for me at first to understand what *level of detail* exactly was required in a User Environment Design, as it seems to by definition be an extremely detailed bridge between the system object model and the user interface.

Something that I found strange, but perhaps it's only because of the research perspective I am accustomed to, is the chapter saying that geographical differences in workplaces are small and usually law-related, and **not culture-related** (p. 952). My first

impression when reading this section was that this seemed inaccurate – from my experience in reading, inherently cultural differences do significantly impact workplace practice. The famous human-computer interaction work Distance matters (Olson & Olson, 2000) describes how cultural differences affect misinterpretation and problems in communication between workplace users in different geographical location, including Europe, East Asia, and the US. There are differences in communication protocols between these places due to cultural values regarding personnel hierarchy, interpersonal concern, and task-oriented level. These are shown to clearly demonstrate inherent cultural values influencing the work practice, beyond what is recommended as just level of *emphasis*, a way of thinking about this encouraged by the chapter. I was unsure why deeper understanding of cultural differences would be less helpful than a simplified reading of all differences as just unrelated, individually varying emphases.